Eventually K. K. Singh walked out of the Ops Room to where Palit was sitting with Brigadier Inder Verma, the Brig Adam of IV Corps. Recalls Palit: ‘With a somewhat derisive smile on his face he flung a copy of a signal on the desk in front of me and said, “So much for your advice on Se-la.”’

The DMO was stunned—he was looking at an operational order from IV Corps HQ to 4 Division granting it permission to withdraw.

‘Who has authorized the withdrawal?’ Palit asked K. K. Singh curtly, hardly able to believe what he was seeing.

‘You can take that up with the corps commander,’ replied the BGS, departing from the room.

Turning to Inder Verma, Palit asked him if he could revoke the signal. Being from the Corps of Signals, the Brig Adam was familiar with the communication network where messages from Tezpur to Dirang Dzong had to be relayed through Bomdila. Since messages had to be ciphered, there would be a delay and the message could be stopped provided Verma could quote the DMO’s authority to cancel it. Palit agreed and the Brig Adam promptly reached for the phone, saying he would do his best to nullify the signal.

Picking up the message sheet, Palit began walking towards the Ops Room. Coming out of the door was Kaul. Palit stopped the corps commander and showed him the signal, asking who had authorized it. Kaul read the message, hesitated briefly, then said, ‘Ask the army commander,’ before walking away.

In the Ops Room General Thapar was sitting and staring vacantly at the map on the wall while Sen and Sibal were talking, seated next to him. Assuming from Kaul’s remark that Bogey Sen had authorized the signal, Palit thrust the message at Thapar. ‘Do you realize, sir, that the army commander has given 4th Division permission to withdraw from Se-la?’

Thapar looked startled and uncomprehending. The contents of the message sheet were obviously news to him. Palit then raised his voice with the intention of getting across to Sen as well, asking the chief ‘how it was that when the Corps Commander was present in his HQ, the Army Commander was issuing operational orders—whereas in the former’s absence he had refused to shoulder any responsibility.’

Sen looked equally startled as he turned towards Palit and Thapar. He asked Palit what was he was talking about. When the contents of the